

Card Workers — Design Document

Last updated: June 2026. Brainstorming phase — no code yet.

Concept

Card Workers is a browser game prototype for hermes-gamelab.

It shares DNA with the Automaton game — workers, cards, a map — but flips the deck mechanic. Instead of each worker owning their own deck, there is **one shared deck** for the player, Slay the Spire style. You draw a hand, assign cards to workers by dragging, and hit Play.

Core Loop

1. Player draws a hand of cards from the shared deck.
 2. Player drags cards onto workers to assign actions (queue them up).
 3. On **Play**, all workers execute simultaneously — each cycling through their assigned cards in a loop.
 4. Workers keep looping indefinitely until the round ends (end condition TBD).
-

Interface

- **Drag card** → **drop on worker** = assign that card's action to that worker.
 - Cards execute in the order they were assigned to each worker. Order matters.
 - Freely reassign / undo until Play is pressed. No commitment before Play.
 - Paradigm mirrors Automaton's drag-onto-resource-node interaction, but the target is now the worker itself.
-

Cards

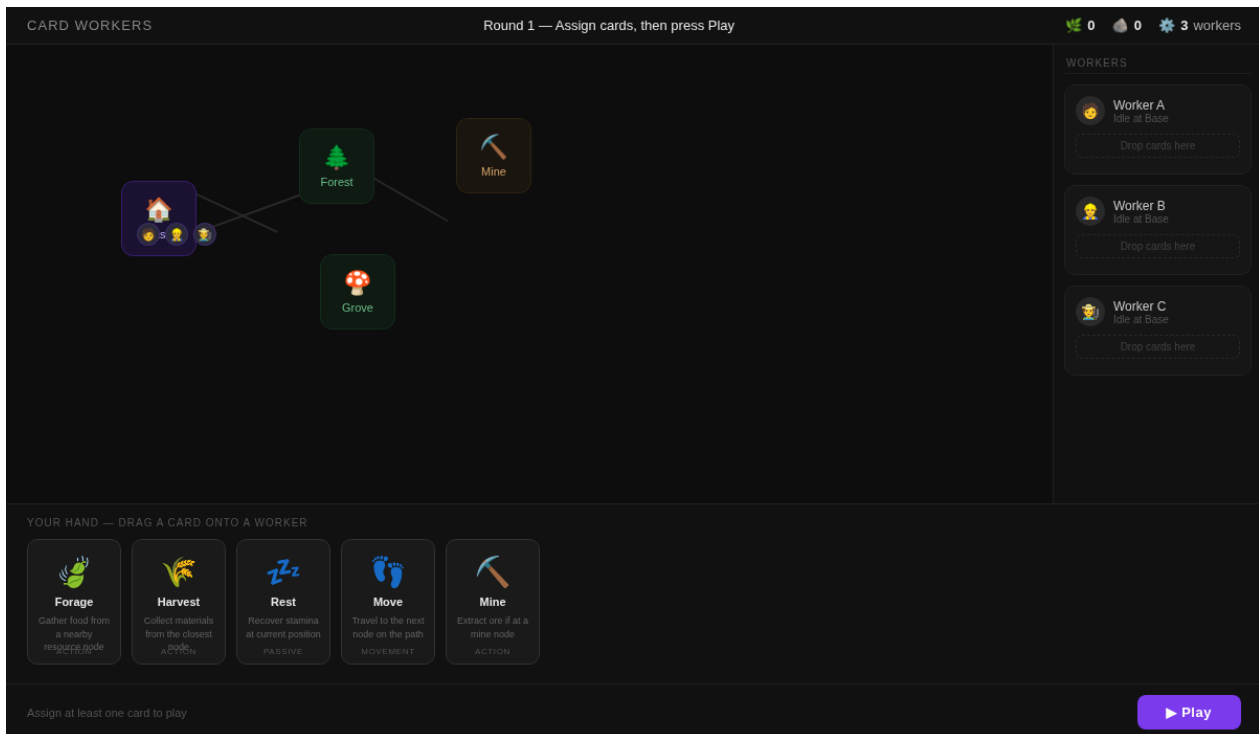
Card	Effect
Forage	Worker goes and forages from a nearby resource.
(more TBD)	

- A card can only be assigned to one worker at a time (implied by shared deck).
-

Interface Sketches

Desktop

Start-of-round layout — before Play is pressed.

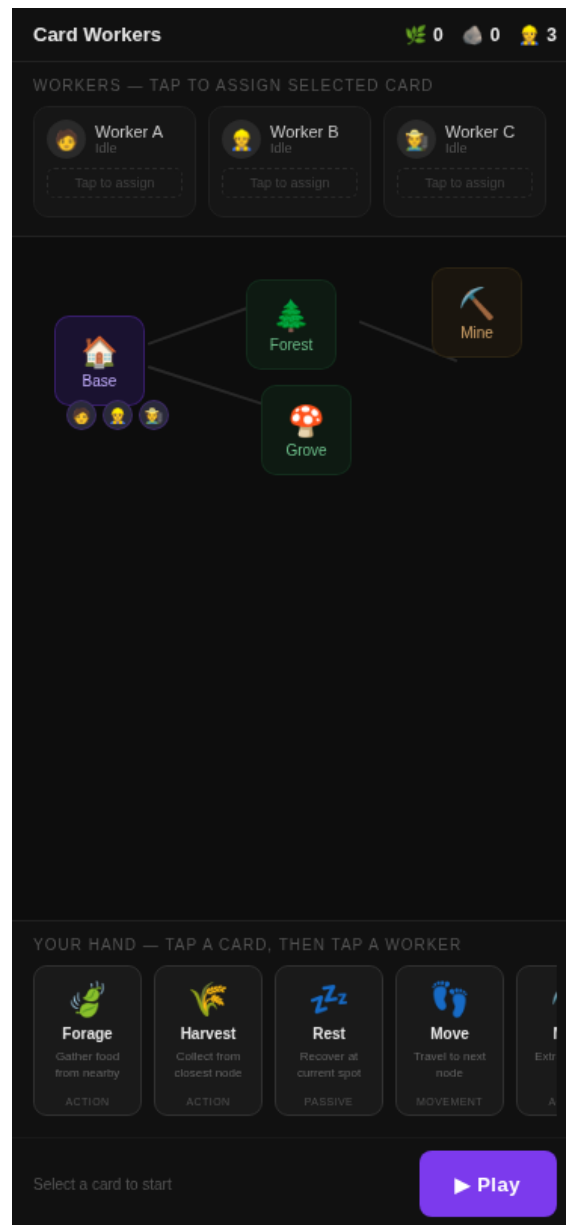


Key areas:

- **Top bar** — round label, resource counters
- **Map (centre-left)** — nodes (Base, Forest, Grove, Mine) with worker tokens idle at Base
- **Workers panel (right)** — one slot per worker; drag cards here to queue actions; X to unassign
- **Hand (bottom)** — your full hand of cards; drag any card onto a worker
- **Play bar** — shows assignment count; big Play button commits the round

Mobile (375px)

Two-tap interaction: tap a card to select it, then tap a worker to assign.



Mobile adaptations:

- **Workers strip** — horizontal scroll across the top; tap a worker after selecting a card
- **Map** — compact centre area; nodes still visible for spatial context
- **Hand** — horizontal scroll at the bottom; tap to select (card lifts), tap again to deselect
- **Assign banner** — purple top banner appears when a card is selected: "Tap a worker to assign"
- **Play bar** — full-width at the bottom, same as desktop

Prototype Scope (v1)

- Single round. No end condition — just explore the interaction feel.
- Workers loop their card queue indefinitely once Play is pressed.
- No deck/discard mechanics yet.

Open Questions

- What triggers end of round / level?
 - Do cards return to hand after a round, or stay assigned?
 - How many workers? How many cards in hand?
 - What other card types beyond Forage?
 - What does the map look like — same node-based map as Automaton, or something new?
-

Relationship to Automaton

	Automaton	Card Workers
Deck	One per worker	One shared deck
Assignment	Card → resource node	Card → worker
Execution	Loop	Loop (simultaneous)
Interface	Drag card onto node	Drag card onto worker